

The Israel CONNECTION

Days after their death, Rabbi Gavriel Holtzberg and wife Rivkah have turned into a mystery of sorts for authorities

Following the great number of calls that have poured in from all over the world, Indian authorities are now seriously wondering who Rabbi Gavriel Holtzberg was. As Director-General Maharashtra Police A.N. Roy puts it, "This is the first time in the history of L&T attacks in India that they've targeted Jews. Deep design, planning, thinking and reconnaissance have gone into this attack."

The Rabbi represented the Chabad movement, one of the biggest Hasidic movements in orthodox Judaism. The move-



NSG COMMANDOS STORM NARIMAN HOUSE (LEFT); RABBI HOLTZBERG AND HIS WIFE RIVKAH



ment runs several Jewish community centres, synagogues and schools. The outreach centre in Colaba, where the Rabbi and his wife Rivkah lived, was home away from home for Israeli backpackers passing through Mumbai.

Neighbours remember the couple as friendly, but aloof. Puran Doshi, one of them, says: "The Rabbi must have been an important man in his community since the consulate car would visit him very often." When the house was stormed by terrorists on November 26, the Rabbi called the consulate for help. The telephone line was cut off in between as the terrorists wanted them to convey their captivity but not the exact number of people who had stormed the building. On getting the news, an armed security officer from the consulate rushed to Chabad House, but was arrested. The terrorists seem to have sent a message to Israel: they can target its people outside the country.

by Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai

Yes, they operated blind without maps while the terrorists seem to know the Taj very well. And yes they have not had training for urban guerrilla warfare. Yet counter terrorism experts ask why it took so long? Why was gas not used in the operations? In Operation Black Thunder, the NSG had used yellow phosphorus to smoke out terrorists. But inexplicably this wasn't done in Mumbai. What is unpardonable is that even this elite force is starved of equipment. Forget the high-end stuff like UAVs or mobile command posts, troopers fought without the basic equipment. Minutes before they took off from Delhi, Black Cats were frantically dialling for ballistic vests to be delivered at the airport. The crisis was aggravated by failure of leadership and total collapse of the system. For instance, though the Trident was secured, hostages were not evacuated till November 28 even though Police Commissioner Hasan Gafoor was parked right outside the hotel.

Even basic information systems were absent. There was no system to guide anxious relatives on who was hurt, killed or held hostage. Rumours ruled the roost. The police didn't know how many terrorists had entered the city. First they said 12, then Deshmukh and Patil said "about 25" and finally 10 have been accounted for. But doubts persist. Were there more? Did they check into the hotels or work there? How did they keep going for 50 hours? Did they pre-plant the ammunition? The blasts at Vile Parle and Wadi Bunder are yet a mystery. Who planted them? Was the airport the target? Over 700 people were evacuated from the hotels without checks. Did some terrorists escape? Are they out there? These queries will haunt Mumbai and India in the coming days.

On Friday night as the crisis dragged on, Patil asked Roy if the Mumbai Police could add to the NSG force to storm the Taj. Gafoor who had already lost men put his foot down. He revealed that they were simply not equipped or trained for this. The average policeman is bogged down in *bandobast* duties through the year and fires less than five bullets at the training range (compared to 150 by any commando force). They were and would have been sitting ducks. That is shocking. But that politicians and babudom have allowed matters to come to such a pass is chilling. It is this rot which passes for security in Mumbai and it is this stench that has fuelled the anger across Mumbai and India.

with Sandeep Unnithan